YOUR SPIRITUAL LIFE

As you know, your personal time with the Lord is very important! Those quiet times spent in praise and worship, prayer and Bible reading, are necessary to your spiritual growth. As a single person, you may have found it hard to fit a quiet time into your schedule or to discipline yourself to have a quiet time. You won't find it to be any easier after you're married. In fact, it will be more difficult. Now, there are two schedules to coordinate, another person that needs your attention and other activities that take your time. Keep in mind that your personal time with Jesus is a priority because your marriage will only be as strong as your relationship is with Jesus.

It may be difficult at first to adjust your schedules to include a quiet time, but if you are diligent and disciplined, things will work out. Be an encouragement to each other, allowing your spouse to have that time alone with Jesus. When your partner is refreshed and encouraged in the presence of the Lord, that refreshment will spill over into the relationship.

Philemon 7 says, *"Your love has given me great joy and encouragement, because you, brother, have refreshed the hearts of the saints."*

Hebrews 10:24-25 says, *"And let us consider how we may spur one another on toward love and good deeds. Let us not give up meeting together, as some are in the habit of doing, but let us encourage one another - and all the more as you see the day approaching."*

This scripture also points out the importance of being in church, to fellowship with people of like-minded faith. This will allow you to be encouraged. Remember, it is pretty difficult to be encouraged if you are not in fellowship with the body of Christ. As you realise the importance and benefits of your quiet time and fellowship time with the body of Christ, you will be encouraged to help each other have a quiet time and be a part of the body of Christ.

ANSWER THE FOLLOWING QUESTIONS:

1. Do you have a personal quiet time with the Lord?

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2. How frequent is your quiet time?

daily

weekly

monthly

several times a week

several times a month

3. Share some of the benefits in your own life that have come from your quiet time:

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4. How would you rate your prayer life?

satisfactory

satisfactory but needing improvement

unsatisfactory

5. What areas, if any, of your prayer life do you feel need improvement?

_____

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6. How would you rate your Bible reading and/or study time?

satisfactory

satisfactory but needing improvement

unsatisfactory

7. What areas, if any, of your Bible reading/study practices do you feel need improvement?

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Look up the following scriptures and write in your own words what these scriptures on prayer mean to you:

Matthew 21:21-22

Matthew 6:5-6

Mark 11:22-26

Matthew 26:41

Acts 6:4

Philippians 4:6-7

James 5:16

Look up the following scriptures on Bible reading and write what they mean to you:

Joshua 1:8

Ezra 7:10

Psalm 1:1-3

Psalm 19:7-11

Psalm 119:9-11,92

John 17:17

2 Timothy 3:16-17

Hebrews 4:12

James 1:22-25

How do you feel you have helped your partner to grow spiritually?

Do you feel there are any areas where you may have hindered their spiritual growth?

God wants us to encourage each other, not only in our private devotions, but also to encourage each other to get together with the body so we can be an encouragement to others. You and your partner are a part of the body, giving strength to it and doing your part to accomplish God's purposes. The following scriptures show us this truth.

I Corinthians 12:12,27,28 says, *"The body is a unit, though it is made up of many parts; and though all its parts are many, they form one body. So, it is with Christ. But in fact, God has arranged the parts in the body, every one of them, just as He wanted them to be. Now you are the body of Christ, and each one of you is a part of it. "*

Ephesians 4:16 says, *"From Him the whole body, joined and held together by every supporting ligament, grows and builds itself up in love, as each part does its work."*

I Corinthians 3:5-8 tells us that the Lord has assigned us each a task, but we all have just one purpose. God intends for each of us to be a vital part of the body that will nourish other parts. Going to church is not just a weekly duty that you perform, where you receive little and give nothing. If it is, your motives are wrong, and some changes need to be made.

We assemble ourselves together, first, to minister to God, then to receive teaching, instruction, exhortation, etc., so that we can reach out and minister to others. You, as a part of the body, have life, love, gifts and abilities flowing through you. Let those things spill over into other members of the body. Remember, you're not concerned for merely your own interests, but for the interests of others. Be a 'need-meeter' through the power of God.

Answer the following questions:

1. Do you attend church regularly? (That means, at the very minimum, once a week)

2. What area or areas are you involved in at church?

3. What area or areas do you see yourself and your partner involved in when you are married?

4. What qualities and/or gifts do you see in your partner that are valuable to the body?

5. What qualities and/or gifts do you see in yourself that are valuable to the body?

Write, in your own words, what the following scriptures mean to you:

I Corinthians 12:12,18,27

Ephesians 4:16

I Corinthians 3:5-8

Hebrews 10:24-25

Galatians 6:1-2

Colossians 3:12-15